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Culture (OWC): [Bagisu \(FK13\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: August 1965-June 1969

Coverage Date: 1960s

Place Coverage

Bugisu District, Mount Elgon region, Uganda

Section Title(S): THE JOKING RELATIONSHIP, BUKULO

THE JOKING RELATIONSHIP, *BUKULO*

In the 1960s, *bukulo* was a hereditary joking relationship which held between members of different lineages and linked members as joking partners (*bakulo*) to each other. In outline, the pattern conforms to that widely reported in Africa in that the partners have licence to revile, abuse, and insult one another and this licence extends to the snatching of property.³ It differs from those reported elsewhere in that joking partners are neither kin nor affines and nor are they linked by the performance of any mutual service, such as funeral or purificatory rites. Nor do they possess any other role in community or kinship affairs such as mediation in disputes. The relationship is thus defined and has meaning solely in terms of the licence given by 'joking', and this licence is explained in terms of prior hostility between the linked lineages. *Bukulo* is thus presented as a peace pact and all its symbolic forms build upon this notion and its dual correlates of amity and enmity.

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Though no longer contracted *bukulo* remains important in central and southern Bugisu. Typically these linkages are found between small lineage segments of approximately three generations in depth of the same clan or sub-clan area. Such lineage segments tend to maintain only one such alliance, though some claim more, but there is no regular pattern. In the present context the broadest generalisation that can safely be made is that the relationship tends to hold between neighbouring but not immediately contiguous lineages. *Bukulo* is incompatible with the etiquette and courtesy which are demanded by kinship and, further, where through migrations and shifts of house-site, *bakulo* find themselves living in immediate proximity to each other, the relationship tends to become subdued in the interests of neighbourly cordiality. *Bukulo* behaviour is at odds with that expected in ordinary social interaction.

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The chief characteristic of *bukulo* behaviour is abuse and this is distinguished from light-hearted jesting and chaffing. It is stressed that *bukulo* exchanges are 'not play' (*xung'aa*) but 'abuse' (*xuxomana*); abuse which may take no note of normal etiquette and of the restrictions of relative sex, age or generation. In practice, the most extreme forms of verbal abuse tend to occur only between those men who are contemporaries and, in my experience, interactions were more restrained between those of the opposite sex. However, in principle, such restraints may be set aside and any type of abuse is licensed. It thus may run the gamut from relatively innocuous remarks over personal appearance ('big head', 'shrivelled body', 'unkempt hair' and the like) to more direct accusations of witchcraft and the type of animal and sexual obscenities which, in other circumstances, would undoubtedly precipitate fighting. All 164 rude personal remarks indeed tend to carry the implication of witchcraft since they play upon the kind of objectionable characteristics which can be taken as the mark of a witch. If witchcraft is imputed to the recipient, however, it is equally incurred by the perpetrator since open abuse and the use of obscenities are seen as a form of cursing (*citsubo*). This is not to say that witchcraft and *bukulo* are in any other ways identified but to emphasise the abnormality of the behaviour; it is beyond the pale.

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3 Radcliffe-Brown (1940a, 1949) defined these joking forms in terms of their essential ambivalence as a 'peculiar combination of friendship and antagonism' (1952:91) which gave expression as he saw it to both the common and the divergent interests of parties to an alliance. See further, p. 217.

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